

The Power of Pre-existing Beliefs: How Misinformation and Vote Choice Influenced Public Trust in Brazil's 2022 Presidential Election

Abstract: Efforts to increase trust in institutions struggle to overcome individuals' prior beliefs. This paper argues that when institutional trust is low, the efficacy of efforts to improve trust is conditional on partisan preferences and pre-existing beliefs. To test this hypothesis, I conducted a survey-experiment in Brazil before the 2022 presidential election. Respondents were randomly assigned to read either neutral or positive headlines and social media posts about Brazilian electoral institutions. Results suggest that exposure to this information impacts perceptions of electoral credibility, conditional on partisan preferences and pre-existing levels of institutional trust. Individuals update their beliefs only when the information confirms what they already thought. The results highlight challenges with correcting misperceptions in a low-trust environment and the limited conditions under which beliefs can be updated.

Keywords: Institutional trust, elections, misinformation, Brazil, experiment

Institutional trust is vital to the functioning of democracy. When individuals distrust elections, they may believe that an election was stolen and lose faith in a fundamental democratic process (Pennycook & Rand, 2021b). Individuals who do not trust the media are less likely to be satisfied with democracy (Rodríguez & Zechmeister, 2018). More broadly, if individuals do not trust governing bodies, the economy suffers, collective action is less likely, government accountability by citizens decreases, and forms of extralegal justice increase, with these challenges being more pronounced in newer democracies like those in Latin America (Keefer & Scartascini, 2022). Furthermore, governmental mistrust will lead some individuals to support more populist than traditional candidates (Keefer & Scartascini, 2022; Masala, 2020), thereby increasing reliance on these candidates for information about what to believe and whom to trust (Druckman et al., 2013).

Distrust in institutions is often driven by misinformation. Specifically, political misinformation, including false claims of electoral fraud and lies about candidates, can undermine trust in democratic institutions, including elections (Valenzuela et al., 2022), with social media exacerbating these effects (Rossini et al., 2023). The negative effects of political misinformation are not limited to newer democracies and autocracies; they can also be seen in established democracies like the United States. Given the prevalence of misinformation globally, scholars and the public are increasingly interested in understanding how these misperceptions can be corrected. These correction efforts have had mixed success (Blair et al., 2023), however, raising questions about whether scholars sufficiently understand the mechanisms underlying the spread of misinformation and if it is possible to prevent negative impacts on democracy.

Existing political beliefs play an especially important role in mediating how individuals seek out and process information and engage with misinformation corrections. Individuals hold

strong attachments to their pre-existing political beliefs and may deliberately seek information confirming these beliefs, even if that information is false (Lewandowsky et al., 2012). These effects are evident when individuals view both factual information and falsehoods (Bachmann et al., 2024). Accordingly, partisan preferences can influence susceptibility to misinformation because individuals are more willing to accept information that is proattitudinal and aligns with their beliefs as true (Batista Pereira et al., 2022; Gehle et al., 2024; Kreiss, 2019; Rossini et al., 2023). These inaccurate beliefs may increase partisan attachments and polarization (Kahan, 2012) and shape which institutions individuals trust (Rossini & Kalogeropoulos, 2021).

One particularly harmful form of misinformation undermines the credibility of elections, widely understood to be a crucial element of democracy (Huntington, 1991). This aspect is particularly evident in Latin America, where social media has facilitated the spread of misinformation that has undermined institutional trust (Lupu et al., 2020). Therefore, I aim to answer the following questions about electoral misinformation: In an environment saturated with false information, which individuals are more likely to respond to factual information about electoral credibility? More specifically, what effect does exposure to information referring to the legitimacy of an election have on an individual's perception of electoral credibility? Rather than focusing on misinformation correction and, specifically, fact-checking, which has been shown to be ineffective in many cases (e.g., Blair et al., 2023), I analyze heterogeneity in the interpretation of factual information based on partisan preferences.

I do so using an online survey experiment fielded in Brazil in September 2022 to test the effects of exposure to truthful claims that the electoral process was legitimate and fair, which I refer to as *positive information*, on perceptions that the election would be fair. I measured baseline levels of institutional trust and post-treatment levels of electoral trust. During the

presidential campaign, Brazil's information environment was saturated with misinformation related to, among many other topics, electoral processes (Horton & Gragnani, 2022). Incumbent Jair Bolsonaro (*Partido Liberal*, PL) repeatedly endorsed false claims about the election's legitimacy (Nicas & Spigariol, 2022). At the same time, his opponent, former president Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva of Brazil's most institutionalized party, the *Partido dos Trabalhadores* (Workers Party, PT), praised the electoral process as free and fair (Marra, 2022). The claims spread rapidly across various social media platforms, from WhatsApp to Twitter (Hale et al., 2024).

Results suggest that it is difficult—but possible—to increase perceptions that electoral institutions are fair. However, effects were almost entirely conditional on partisan preferences and existing levels of institutional trust. When the information presented was counterattitudinal, based on partisan preferences, perceptions of electoral credibility *decreased*. When the information was proattitudinal, based on partisan preferences, individuals' perceptions of electoral credibility *increased*. These findings suggest that it is difficult to correct misperceptions in cases when the corrective information does not align with individuals' pre-existing beliefs.

This paper has three main contributions. First, it finds that institutional trust is conditional on partisan preferences, and that these preferences serve as the filters through which information is processed. Second, this paper highlights the possibility that misperceptions about political institutions can be corrected—albeit in a small subset of the population who are already more trusting of institutions and for whom the information presented confirms their existing beliefs. Finally, this paper broadens our understanding of how exposure to misinformation harms democratic institutions, focusing on newer democracies. In Brazil, the prevalence of political misinformation, especially on social media, undermined faith in one of Brazil's core and

historically most trusted democratic institutions. The results in this paper demonstrate one reason why it is so challenging to combat these effects, showing the influence of identity on electoral trust in Brazil and, likely, other countries in Latin America. By increasing awareness of how identity influences the efficacy of interventions, misinformation corrections may become more effective for a larger share of the population.

Misinformation and Partisanship Can Undermine Institutional Trust

When institutional trust is undermined, there are negative repercussions for democracy. High-trust societies have less corruption and more functional government (Uslaner, 2002). Additionally, in countries with lower levels of institutional trust, accountability of elected officials is more challenging (Keefer & Scartascini, 2022). However, the quality of institutions often affects the extent to which individuals trust them (Dahlberg & Linde, 2018).

Media content also matters for understanding institutional trust. Existing literature suggests that institutional trust is affected by media coverage that is supportive or unsupportive (Moy et al., 1999). Online, algorithms, in combination with the media individuals select, can potentially amplify these effects (Noh & Soroka, 2025). Misinformation and disinformation (Mauk & Grömping, 2023)—where misinformation is defined as information that is spread without knowledge of its inaccuracy, while disinformation adds a layer of malicious intent (Lim & Donovan, 2020)—and social media (Klein & Robison, 2020) in particular can also affect levels of trust both positively and negatively. The starting point for the analyses that follow is thus:

H1: Interacting with positive information about the electoral process will lead to an increase in one's perceptions of its credibility.

There is, of course, a growing body of work suggesting heterogeneity in the effects of information about the electoral process and institutional trust more broadly. The strength of partisanship can moderate media effects, for instance. Stronger partisan preferences are associated with increased affective polarization (Hernández et al., 2021) and decreased interpersonal trust (Hooghe & Oser, 2017). In the United States, Levitsky and Ziblatt (2018) explain that institutional trust is undermined when a president lies to citizens, as it becomes more difficult to hold elected officials accountable. As a result, citizens lack faith in their representatives and leaders, and democracy suffers. These beliefs also influence satisfaction with democracy (Blais & Gélneau, 2007).

Confirmation bias also moderates media effects. Individuals tend to believe information that confirms their beliefs (Gehle et al., 2024; Roozenbeek et al., 2022), and this confirmation bias leads them to be highly resistant to change (Lewandowsky et al., 2012) while also clouding their ability to accurately judge facts (Bachmann et al., 2024; Kahan et al., 2017). Some studies found that certain other characteristics, such as age and media literacy skills, can increase one's propensity to believe misinformation (Scherer & Pennycook, 2020). However, confirmation bias has repeatedly been shown to contribute to the spread of misinformation (Little, 2019; Treen et al., 2020).¹ Furthermore, confirmation bias strengthens people's pre-existing beliefs by generating more arguments that support them (Baron, 2019) and driving selective exposure (Van der Meer et al., 2020).²

Individuals will also intentionally seek out information that reflects positively on their partisan in-group (Peterson & Iyengar, 2021). For example, partisanship influenced individuals'

¹ The connection between misinformation and institutional trust is cyclical: Misinformation can decrease trust in institutions (Valenzuela et al., 2022), and a lack of trust in institutions is associated with greater belief in anti-government conspiracies (Freeman et al., 2022). For example, false claims of electoral fraud can decrease trust in elections, and variations in trust can be attributed to partisanship (Levitsky & Ziblatt, 2018).

² Repeatedly seeing multiple pieces of information that say similar things can also lead people to believe it is true (Foster et al., 2012; Lewandowsky et al., 2012).

opinions regarding the COVID-19 vaccine (Ebeling et al., 2022). It may also influence assessments of corruption (Anduiza et al., 2013). Additional examples of belief updating conditional on partisanship have been observed in countries such as Venezuela (Andrade, 2021), Côte d'Ivoire (Gottlieb et al., 2022), and India (Badrinathan, 2021).

Due to the influences of partisanship, confirmation bias, and misinformation, efforts have been made to correct these inaccurate or biased beliefs. Fact-checking, while common, may not be effective (Blair et al., 2023; Lim & Donovan, 2020) or it may only work in some contexts (Bachmann & Valenzuela, 2023). Similarly, media literacy workshops may not be effective in equipping individuals with the tools to combat misinformation (Badrinathan, 2021) or may be effective only in certain circumstances, such as in a classroom with a fixed curriculum (Dumitru et al., 2022; Edwards et al., 2021). Nudges, a strategy that encourages people to share or believe only accurate information, may be somewhat effective in reducing belief in misinformation (Arechar et al., 2023; Scherer & Pennycook, 2020). Finally, inoculation, or pre-bunking, may effectively reduce belief in false information (Batista Pereira et al., 2022). Overall, corrections may improve one's ability to identify accurate information regardless of partisanship (Weeks, 2015), but their effectiveness is often limited to specific contexts, such as a classroom setting or a particular country or aspect of the intervention.

Even when efforts to correct misinformed beliefs are successful, there can be unintended consequences. Pre-existing beliefs make correction efforts more difficult (Born, 2017; Lodge & Taber, 2013). A troubling unintended consequence is the backfire effect, where attempts to correct misinformation may unintentionally strengthen existing beliefs (Lewandowsky et al., 2012). However, as Coppock (2022) argues, individuals actually update their beliefs in the direction of the information provided, even if it is counterattitudinal. Regardless, efforts to

correct misinformation may not lead individuals to update their beliefs in the intended direction.

Given the influence of existing levels of institutional trust and partisan preferences in how people process information, I propose two more hypotheses:

H2: Effect sizes will be smaller for individuals for whom the treatment information is counterattitudinal based on their partisan preferences.

H3: Effect sizes will be smaller for individuals with lower levels of institutional trust, as they will be less likely to respond to treatment. Individuals with higher baseline levels of institutional trust will be more likely to perceive the election as credible.

Institutional Trust, Partisanship, and (Mis)information in Brazil

The contextual factors surrounding institutional trust and partisanship in Brazil provide an ideal case for studying the relationship between these factors and belief in information. Brazil has one of the lowest levels of institutional and interpersonal trust in Latin America. As a region, Latin America has an average level of trust below that of the rest of the world (Keefer & Scartascini, 2022). Specifically, levels of electoral trust are relatively low in Latin America (Carreras & İrepoğlu, 2013). Much of the reason for low institutional trust can be attributed, at least in part, to misinformation spreading on social media (Valenzuela et al., 2022).

There are historical explanations for Brazil's lower levels of trust in institutions than those of other Latin American countries. Namely, Brazil has struggled with relatively low levels of electoral trust since 2007.³ Since 2010, Brazil has faced a series of protests and corruption scandals, beginning with the jornadas de junho in 2013. Originally a protest over an increase in public transportation prices, the movement became focused on dissatisfaction with Brazil's

³ Appendix E.1 breaks down individual measures of trust in Brazil over time.

political system. While the government attempted to respond to the protesters' requests, the movement fostered mistrust of institutions and heightened the politicization of the Brazilian public, particularly toward the PT (Yamaguti, 2023).

In 2016, President Dilma Rousseff (PT) was impeached, in part, for her handling of revelations about Lava Jato (Operation Car Wash), a corruption scandal in Brazil that culminated in the indictment of many high-ranking government officials, including Lula. Rousseff's impeachment and ongoing protests during her successor's term led many Brazilians to seek something different politically. This dissatisfaction is likely one of the reasons why Bolsonaro, who painted himself as a political outsider, was elected in 2018 (Furtado, 2019). Furthermore, as both Bolsonaro and Lula were populist candidates, individuals may have been more likely to trust their rhetoric (Keefer & Scartascini, 2022; Masala, 2020).

During the 2022 campaign, Bolsonaro and Lula's platforms differed substantially on issues ranging from security to healthcare (Barifouse et al., 2022). One of the most notable differences was their views on the legitimacy of the electoral process, particularly regarding electronic voting machines. Electronic voting machines have been used in Brazilian elections since 1996 and have a reputation for reliability (Ribbeiro, 2026). Still, Bolsonaro frequently and vehemently attacked the machines (Nicas & Spigariol, 2022) and repeatedly claimed that, if he lost, the election must have been stolen (Faiola, 2022) and that government employees could tamper with machines. On the other hand, Lula's platform praised the electronic voting machines, highlighting their historic reliability, and emphasized the need for a democratic Brazil (Marra, 2022). The candidates' opposing narratives about the credibility of the electoral process affected public perceptions. In July 2022, 31 percent of Bolsonaro supporters did not trust the voting machines compared to 14 percent of Lula supporters (Datafolha, 2022). These elite cues

were central to determining levels of electoral trust, particularly regarding electronic voting machines (Mello & Jurado, 2026). Furthermore, misinformation contributed to the politicization of voting machines and to broader skepticism toward the electoral process (Nicas & Spigariol, 2022).

Much of this elite rhetoric and misinformation spread on social media (Rossini et al., 2023), including Facebook, Instagram, Twitter, and WhatsApp (Galhardi et al., 2022). As a result, the information environment became saturated with facts and misinformation about the electoral process, with opinions of its legitimacy depending on which candidate one supported. For instance, Batista Pereira et al. (2022) find that partisan motivated reasoning drives belief in information. Specifically, individuals with more right-wing beliefs are more likely to believe misinformation (Rossini & Kalogeropoulos, 2021; Rossini et al., 2023), and Bolsonaro supporters are more likely to believe misinformation and conspiracy theories about the COVID-19 pandemic (Gramacho et al., 2021). Since exposure to electoral misinformation occurred on social media and belief was driven by partisan preferences, I propose a fourth and final hypothesis:

H4: Individuals who use social media frequently will be less likely to view the election as credible. Partisan preferences will moderate this effect.

In summary, an individual's level of trust in institutions and their partisan preferences influence perceptions of electoral credibility. Brazil, given its lower levels of institutional trust, a saturated information environment, and the influence of partisanship, provides an ideal case for studying factors that shape the relationship between information about the electoral process and perceptions of electoral credibility, as well as those that influence only the latter. It remains uncertain, however, how trust may influence partisanship and how partisanship may influence

the relationship between information exposure and perceptions of electoral credibility.

Methods

To understand how factual information impacted perceptions of electoral credibility, I conducted a survey experiment in September 2022, the month before the presidential election.⁴ It was conducted prior to the election and runoff to eliminate the possibility of partisan biases being introduced based on the election's winner. The first section asked basic demographic questions about partisan preferences, measured by vote choice in the 2018 election, and social media usage. The second section asked participants to rate their trust in various political institutions on a seven-point Likert scale. The six trust measures included: Congress, the judiciary, the presidency, elections, the military, and traditional media sources.

For the third section, participants were randomly assigned to the experimental or control group, with 50 percent in each group.⁵ In the first subsection, participants were presented with a headline and asked (1) if they believed it to be true, measured with a four-point Likert scale, and (2) with whom they would most likely share it. In the following subsection, participants saw a mock Facebook post resembling an anonymous poster sharing an article. Each mock post had many likes, comments, and shares. An example of a positive mock post is shown in Figure 1. All respondents in the control group saw the same set of three headlines and three mock posts. Respondents in the treatment group saw the same headlines as the control with the addition of two positive headlines and three positive mock posts. After completing the survey, respondents

⁴ The University of California, Los Angeles Human Research Protection Program approved this study (IRB# 22-001274).

⁵ 472 respondents were in the control group, and 400 respondents were in the treatment group. To check whether individuals in the treatment and control groups passed the attention check question at the same rate, I estimated a 2SLS model using treatment status as an instrument for passing the attention check. Pass rates were nearly identical, with 84% in the treatment group and 81.4% in the control group passing. Additionally, the instrument diagnostic was weak, confirming that treatment status does not predict whether someone answers the attention check question correctly. Full results are shown in Appendix E.5.

were debriefed on its contents. It was explained that the posts they saw were not real, but the information was factual and from reputable Brazilian newspapers. Additionally, I intentionally did not pretest belief or willingness to share the headlines and mock social media posts as I was concerned about priming.



Figure 1: Sample positive mock social media post. Translation: “Learn why e-voting is safe in a new video series about the 2022 elections.”

Respondents in the treatment group were exposed to factual information that praised the legitimacy of the electoral process (positive information) and general facts about the election (neutral facts). Those in the control group just saw neutral facts. Headlines were taken from reputable Brazilian news sources, including *Folha de S. Paulo*, *O Globo*, and *Jornal do Brasil*. Sources were not disclosed to isolate the effects of the information contained in the headline. No headline mentioned a particular candidate by name. Rather, each focused on the election itself or

the electoral process. Neutral headlines were facts about the election. For example, one headline taken from *Jornal do Brasil* (translated) reads, “More than 156 million people are eligible to vote in October” (JB, 2022). This headline and the other neutral headlines were facts about the election itself and did not praise or criticize the electoral process. Positive headlines praised the electoral process, discussing its legitimacy or widespread support. For instance, Figure 1 shows a headline taken from *Folha de S. Paulo* (translated) that reads, “Learn why e-voting is safe in a new video series about the 2022 elections” (Lourenço, 2022). Like other positive headlines, it praises the electoral process by stating that the oft-attacked voting machines are safe. Since the survey was fielded in the weeks before the first round of the election, I only chose to include factual information detailing how the election would be fair. While this decision meant that I did not test the influence of information that would be proattitudinal for Bolsonaro supporters and counterattitudinal for Lula supporters, it was an ethical consideration not to include misinformation about the legitimacy of the electoral process so close to the first round of voting.⁶

The fourth and final section asked questions about the 2022 presidential election. First, respondents were asked about their voting intention in the likely event of a runoff between Lula and Bolsonaro. They were then asked to rate how credible they believed the election to be on a six-point Likert scale. Those who rated their perceived credibility as low were then asked why they believed the election was not fair and asked to rank given choices from a list. These choices can be sorted into three major groups: elite messaging, information networks, and institutions. Those who rated their perceived credibility as high were asked an identical question, except that the language asked why they trusted the election.

⁶ By providing this false information, I would have knowingly spread disinformation about the election’s legitimacy. The information may have influenced individuals’ perceptions of the candidates and the electoral process, leading to possible harms to democracy. These decisions were made intentionally and with the knowledge that it would mean I would be unable to directly test the effects of misinformation on individuals’ perceptions of electoral credibility. Rather, I would investigate the role of factual information that highlighted the election’s legitimacy.

Sample

In total, 1,000 individuals responded to the survey. Of these, 872 answered the attention check question correctly, and their responses were included in the analysis. I included quotas for age, gender, and ethnicity to roughly match the demographic makeup of the Brazilian population. Given that the survey was conducted online, the sample is slightly skewed towards those with more years of education. Even so, the sample remains balanced between the treatment and control groups. Complete demographic information and balance tables are provided in Appendix B.

Participants were recruited through the survey company Cint. Individuals who were a part of Cint's panel and met certain demographic criteria (e.g., age or gender) were invited to participate in the study. Potential respondents were informed only that they qualified for the survey, that participation was voluntary, and that they would receive an incentive for participating. They were not given any information about the study's purpose until the post-survey debrief.

Model Specification and Measures

The data was analyzed using the following regression model:

$$Y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X_T + \beta_2 X_X + \beta_3 X_T X_X + \epsilon$$

Y represents the primary outcome of interest, perceptions of electoral credibility. A lower score indicated that respondents did not trust the 2022 electoral process, while a higher score indicates that they did. X_T is a dummy variable indicating if someone was randomly assigned to the treatment (1) or control (0) group. X_X is a dummy variable used to represent variables of

interest. For example, the second hypothesis represents whether an individual voted for Bolsonaro (1) or not (0). To rule out the possibility that treatment affected vote choice, I included an indicator of whether the respondent voted for Bolsonaro in 2018. One concern is that treatment status may have affected reported vote choice. This was not the case. Only a few voters switched from Bolsonaro in 2018 to Lula in 2022, and any party switch did not significantly affect the final results. Additionally, treatment status did not significantly influence whether or not someone reported switching their vote.⁷ A breakdown of these results is provided in Appendix B.

Additionally, to understand how institutional trust may vary by partisan preferences, I conducted a Principal Component Analysis (PCA). A PCA is a technique used to identify patterns in complex, high-dimensional data. In this project, prior to treatment, participants responded to a battery of six questions about institutional trust, rating the extent to which they trusted the judiciary, Congress, elections, the presidency, the military, and the media on a 1-7 Likert scale. As I did not anticipate that individuals who trusted one of these institutions would trust others (for instance, a Bolsonaro supporter may be more inclined to trust the military than elections), I used a PCA to identify which measures of institutional trust are correlated.

Results

Hypothesis 1 predicted that exposure to positive information would increase an individual's perception that the electoral process would be fair. Overall, treatment did not significantly affect perceptions of electoral credibility. There are, however, small heterogeneous effects when the sample is divided by vote choice, initial levels of institutional trust, and social

⁷ Due to the stability of these preferences over the course of two elections, I used an individual's vote choice as a measure of partisanship. While this indicator does not fully grasp the complexity of partisanship in Brazil, I only asked about vote choice in the survey.

media usage. These effects are only present for a specific type of person: a Lula supporter who was already inclined to trust institutions. The treatment primed individuals to think about the electoral process, but their reactions depended on their pre-survey beliefs and on whether those beliefs were confirmed or contradicted.

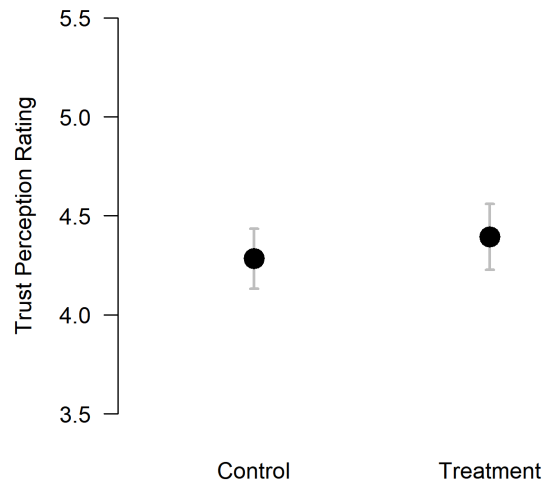


Figure 2: Overall treatment effects; error bars represent 95% confidence intervals

Figure 2 shows the overall effects divided by treatment status. There are no overall or weak treatment effects (at the 0.95 level). Therefore, I reject the first hypothesis on the overall effects of treatment. All regression tables can be found in Appendix C.

Hypothesis 2 predicted heterogeneous effects of partisan preferences. As illustrated in Figure 3, the treatment had only weak effects among supporters of Bolsonaro and Lula. After exposure to treatment, Lula supporters' perceptions that the election would be fair did not change significantly. Perceptions of Bolsonaro supporters decreased significantly, but the effect sizes were small.

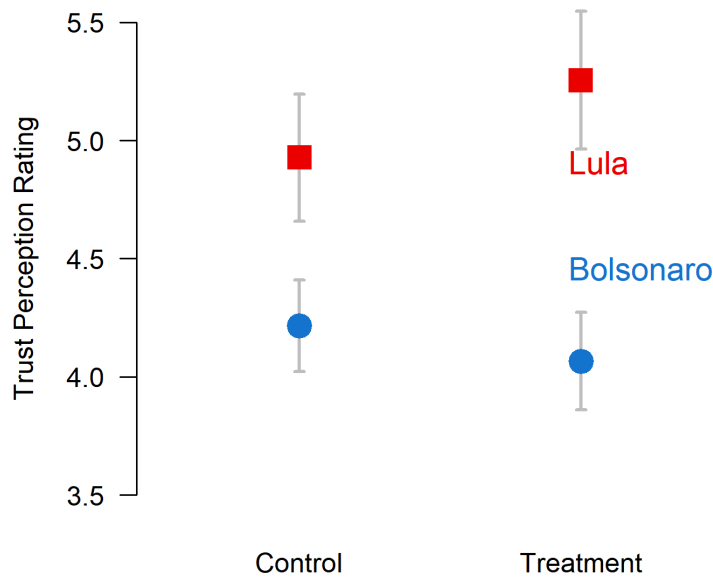


Figure 3: Treatment effects conditional on vote choice; error bars represent 95% confidence intervals

Furthermore, there is a statistically significant difference between the ratings of Lula and Bolsonaro supporters, which I refer to as a *perceptions gap*. If the perceptions gap does not exist among the control group but widens significantly among the treated or exists in the control but closes among the treated, then there was some degree of belief updating. In Figure 3, the perceptions gap *did* widen, but not significantly.

On average, Lula supporters, regardless of treatment status, were more likely to rate their perceptions of electoral credibility higher than Bolsonaro supporters. Considering Bolsonaro's negative rhetoric towards the electoral process and Lula's praise for it, this result makes sense. Bolsonaro supporters were three times more likely to list Bolsonaro's messaging as one of the reasons why they believed the election was not credible, when compared to Lula's supporters, who listed Lula's messaging as a reason why they believed the election was fair. These results suggest that elite messaging was important in establishing how individuals formed their beliefs.⁸

⁸ While expressive responding could also explain these effects, this is unlikely to be the case, as the majority of the

Hypothesis 3 predicted that existing levels of institutional trust would condition the efficacy of treatment. These results can also be used to understand *why* partisan effects exist. Results from the PCA show a split along two dimensions.⁹ The first dimension includes trust in Congress, the judiciary, elections, and traditional news media. The second dimension combines trust in the presidency and the military. Each dimension can be interpreted as aligning with one of the candidates' rhetorics, at least within the context of the 2022 election and campaign. Lula, for instance, was more supportive of the electoral process and traditional media sources. Furthermore, Brazil's Electoral Court is affiliated with the country's Supreme Court. The question's wording asked broadly about trust in the judiciary. Therefore, respondents may have interpreted this question as reflecting trust in the Supreme Court and, by extension, in the Electoral Court, given its salience around the time of the election. Dimension one can be interpreted as trust in institutions that Lula supported and will be referred to as dimension-L.

The second dimension, which will be referred to as dimension-B, can be interpreted as types of trust associated with Bolsonaro and the institutions he supported. First, individuals likely interpreted the question about trusting the presidency as a question about trusting the incumbent, Bolsonaro. Second, Bolsonaro was supportive of the military, even claiming that the dictatorship was a "very good" period for Brazil (Reeves, 2018). When his supporters stormed the capital after Lula's inauguration, they demanded a return to military rule. Bolsonaro supporters, therefore, were more likely to rate trust in the presidency and military higher than other aspects of institutional trust.

These results point to an interesting dynamic of institutional trust: In polarized environments, when individuals respond to survey questions about institutional trust and evaluate

effects are null.

⁹ Additional tests related to the PCA, including analyzing trust with an additive index, can be found in Appendix D.

political institutions in their everyday lives, they likely conflate their responses with their opinions on the incumbent government and their partisan preferences. Institutional trust serves as an extension and indirect measure of partisan preferences. As a result, it is challenging to disentangle trust in an institution from trust in its leaders.

Simply averaging the responses to the battery of six trust questions did not accurately or comprehensively capture how individuals view institutions. The PCA is helpful for understanding why the partisan effects seen in Figure 3 exist and demonstrates that individuals interpret questions on trust through the lens of partisan preferences. Lula supporters were likelier to have higher levels of dimension-L trust, while Bolsonaro supporters were likelier to have higher levels of dimension-B trust. While theoretically these items should be separate, individuals associate institutions with political leaders, even when there is not a direct link between them.

Figure 4 shows estimated treatment effects, allowing for heterogeneity across different levels of institutional trust. In order to analyze differences among subgroups within each dimension, the sample was divided into those with higher and lower scores along a given dimension. Individuals with dimension scores above zero (essentially the mean and median of both groups) were rated as “high” in that dimension. Those who scored less than or equal to zero were divided into that dimension's “low” scoring group. The figure shows the effects of treatment on individuals with high and low levels of dimension-L trust, stratified by vote choice. Results suggest no large effect of treatment on perceptions of electoral credibility. Individuals who are more trusting of Congress, the judiciary, elections, and traditional news media are no more likely than those who are less trusting of these institutions to perceive the presidential election as credible.

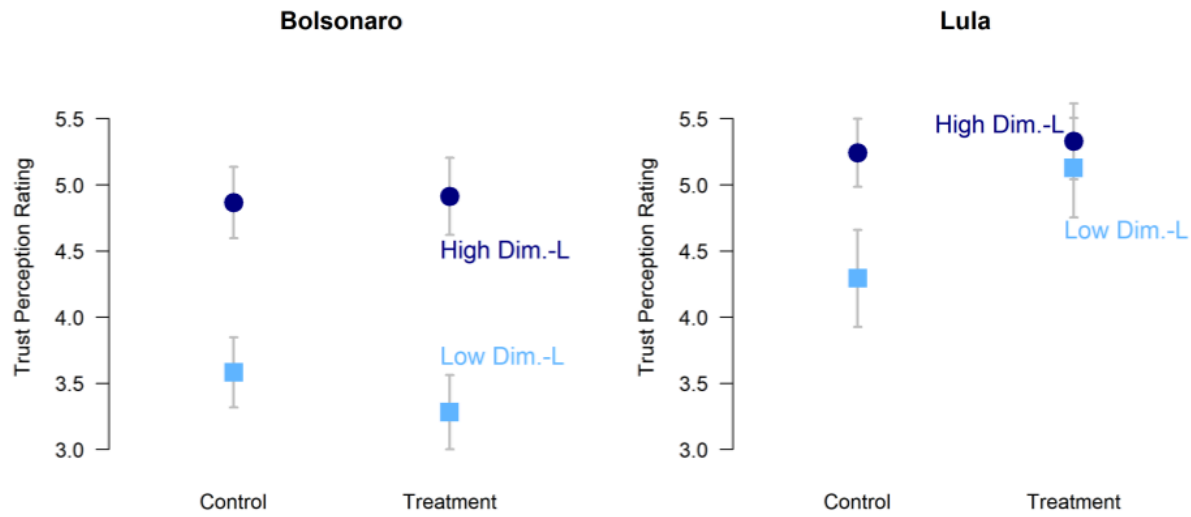


Figure 4: Treatment effects conditional on dimension-L trust (trust in Congress, the judiciary, elections, and traditional media sources); error bars represent 95% confidence intervals

Bolsonaro supporters did not update their beliefs after treatment. The perceptions gap did not change significantly. Additionally, there were no weak effects among individuals with high or low trust. Existing beliefs related to the election were unchanged by treatment. For Lula supporters, however, the perceptions gap closes when participants are exposed to positive information about the election. Among individuals in the control group, there was a statistically significant difference between those with higher and lower levels of dimension-L trust. The perceptions gap disappeared, with low dimension-L individuals increasing to the levels of high dimension-L individuals among those in the treatment group.

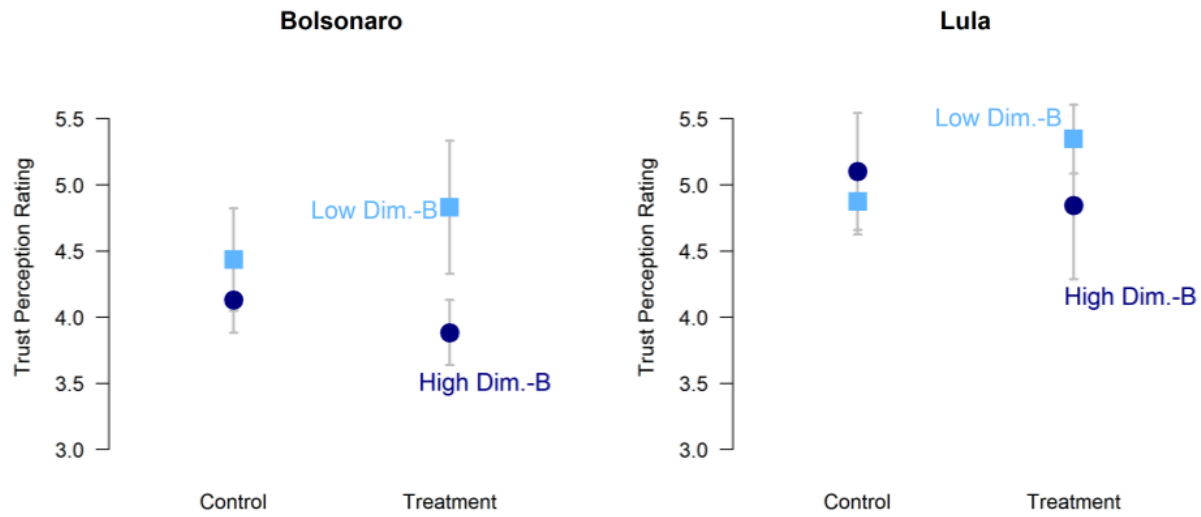


Figure 5: Treatment effects conditional on dimension-B trust (trust in the presidency and the military); error bars represent 95% confidence intervals

Figure 5 shows treatment effects across low and high scores on dimension-B institutional trust. There are two primary findings among Bolsonaro supporters. First, individuals with lower levels of dimension-B trust were more likely to trust elections than those with higher levels of dimension-B trust. Perceptions of electoral credibility appear to be negatively correlated with dimension-B trust. Second, the perceptions gap widens. In the control group, the perception ratings of supporters with high and low dimension-B scores were not statistically different from each other. Among the treated, however, supporters with high levels of dimension-B trust were significantly less likely to trust the election compared to those with lower levels of dimension-B trust. These effects, again, are small and only significant at the 0.1 level.

For Lula supporters, while there was no statistically significant difference between treatment and control, and the perceptions gap did not change significantly, there were weak and minimal effects of treatment. Treated individuals with lower levels of dimension-B trust had

higher perceptions of electoral credibility. Those with higher levels of dimension-B trust had lower perceptions, although this coefficient is only significant at the 0.1 level.

Treatment effects are observed only among Lula supporters who already trust institutions. Lula expressed faith in the electoral process and the legitimacy of the elections, and these claims were an important aspect of his platform. Even respondents who supported Lula but had lower levels of dimension-L trust were more responsive to the treatment. Any treatment effects, however, were small.

On the other hand, Bolsonaro claimed that the electoral process was unfair, and many of his supporters accepted these claims as true (or likely true). When exposed to positive information, Bolsonaro supporters were unlikely, and potentially unwilling, to update their beliefs because it did not confirm them. Bolsonaro supporters were also less likely to believe information that praised the electoral process when compared to neutral facts. They were also less likely to report wanting to share positive information with a wider social network (see Appendix E.3). Ultimately, these results were influenced by the extent to which Bolsonaro supporters trusted political institutions. Respondents who trusted the presidency and military more—and, as a likely extension, Bolsonaro’s narrative—were less likely to trust the electoral process.

Finally, Hypothesis 4 predicted that individuals who use social media more frequently, particularly those who are also Bolsonaro supporters, would be less likely to perceive the election to be credible. Respondents were asked how frequently they use social media for political reasons. Those who reported using social media at least once daily were classified as frequent social media users, while those who reported using it once weekly or less were considered infrequent users. The results broken down by social media use are shown in Figure 6.

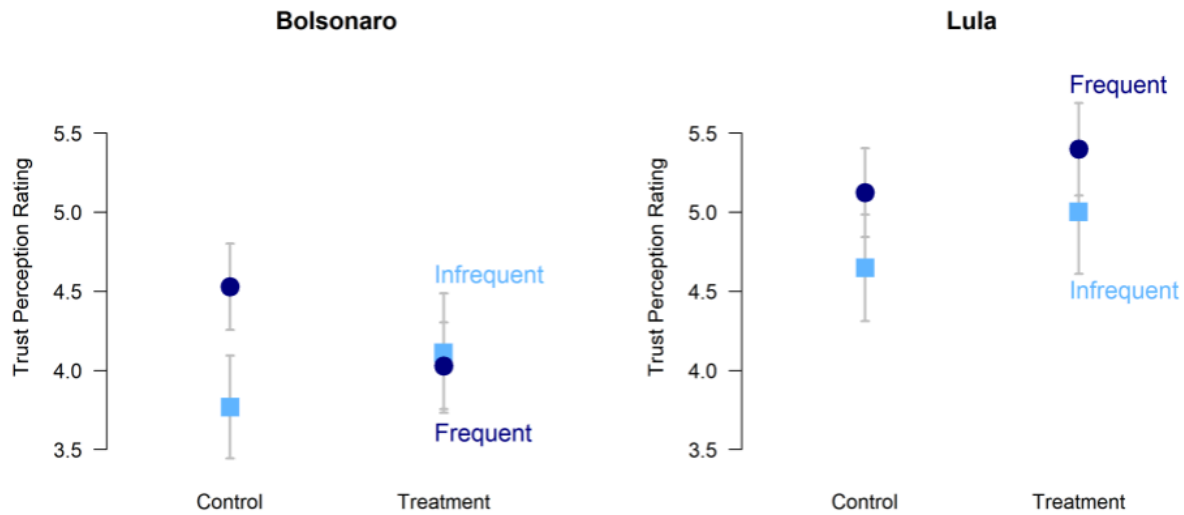


Figure 6: Treatment effects conditional on the frequency of social media use; error bars represent 95% confidence intervals

When looking at just Bolsonaro supporters, the perceptions gap between frequent and infrequent social media users closes after treatment. As in Figure 5, individuals appear to have updated their beliefs in line with the narrative they trusted more. Perceptions of credibility for Bolsonaro supporters who frequently used social media for political reasons decreased significantly between the control and treatment groups. Again, any treatment effects are small. In particular, the positive information in the treatment was contrary to Bolsonaro's narrative of a fraudulent election. Exposure to this information may have led Bolsonaro supporters to, at least momentarily, solidify their initial beliefs.

The results for Lula supporters are not statistically significant in the treatment group. Even so, the information in the treatment only confirmed what Lula supporters likely already believed. There would be no difference between frequent and infrequent social media users, as the information would affect them in the same way.

In summary, the positive information in the treatment affected subgroups differently, with

results ultimately being conditional on vote choice. Treatment effects were observed across groups in tests of institutional trust and social media use. Small treatment effects were only seen for respondents who were Lula supporters and trusted institutions. For this specific type of person, the information provided confirmed their pre-existing beliefs, and these beliefs were updated. For all other respondents, the information contradicted or had no effect on their existing beliefs.

Discussion

This paper extends our existing understanding of belief updating in low-trust environments as well as those with weaker party systems. Results show that efforts to increase institutional trust struggle to overcome confirmation bias, as pre-existing beliefs are unlikely to change. Instead, individuals interpret new information in an expected direction, and these updates are conditional on vote choice. Across all subdivisions of partisanship, trust, and social media usage, vote choice was the most notable predictor of the efficacy of treatment only when combined with existing levels of trust. Bolsonaro supporters were more likely to reject information praising the electoral process, resulting in a null or negative effect. Lula supporters were more likely to accept the treatment, which was associated with an increase in their perceptions that the election would be fair.

The study demonstrates how initial levels of trust determine how individuals process new information, making it challenging to build institutional trust in a low-trust environment. Importantly, it speaks to dangers that can arise when trust in elections is split along seemingly partisan lines. When individuals rely on cues from party leaders and co-partisans to indicate what to trust, they are increasingly likely to reject counterattitudinal information.

Rejection of counterattitudinal information has three effects. First, the more individuals reject counterattitudinal information, the more polarized their beliefs will likely become. When individuals selectively expose themselves to proattitudinal information while rejecting information that contradicts their beliefs, their beliefs may, in turn, become more polarized (Levendusky, 2013).

Second, a lack of trust in traditional media sources creates an environment where misinformation can flourish. In Brazil, and across Latin America, trust in traditional media has declined, leading individuals to obtain news from social media or peers (Carro, 2023). It becomes easier for individuals to find and spread information that confirms their beliefs, regardless of its veracity.

Third, when individuals are less likely to interact with counterattitudinal information, misinformation correction efforts become more difficult. Efforts such as inoculation, media literacy, and fact-checking all require exposing individuals to counterattitudinal information. As a result, individuals are less likely to interact with the intervention. Future research should investigate whether misinformation correction interventions can be more effective at reducing belief in false information if they take aspects like social identity into account, specifically partisan preferences, or incorporate nudges or warnings that individuals may encounter information that goes against their beliefs. Efforts must also consider that, while misperception correction is possible, it will likely succeed only for the subset of the population for whom the corrections and information are proattitudinal.

A final implication of the study concerns the importance of elite rhetoric for trust. Political (and social media) elites have the unique ability to instill faith in, or cast doubt on, institutions vital to the functioning of democracy. In Brazil, Bolsonaro expressed faith in the

military and himself as the president, and his supporters followed. Lula vocally supported elections, the judiciary, and the media, and his followers trusted those institutions. Elite political rhetoric affects how individuals view information, process new material, and trust institutions—especially when they may not initially trust these institutions. As a result, politicians may be vital in efforts to combat misinformation, but more research is needed to understand the impacts of elite rhetoric on belief in misinformation and how these patterns play out in newer democracies (Blair et al., 2023).

Overall, in countries with weak institutional trust, individuals update their beliefs in a predictable direction that is conditional on partisan preferences. Rebuilding electoral trust in Latin America is, therefore, hindered by the effects of pre-existing beliefs. Elite rhetoric plays an important role in shaping how individuals view institutions, such as elections, and how they respond to new information, and perhaps could be part of the answer to rebuilding institutional trust. Ultimately, trust and partisanship are the most important determinants of how individuals process new information.

References

- AmericasBarometer. (2021). www.vanderbilt.edu/lapop
- Andrade, G. (2021). Belief in Conspiracy Theories About COVID-19 Amongst Venezuelan Students: A Pilot Study. *Revista Colombiana de Psicología*, 30 (1), 79-88.
<https://doi.org/10.15446/rcp.v30n1.87357>
- Anduiza, E., Gallego, A., & Muñoz, J. (2013). Turning a Blind Eye: Experimental Evidence of Partisan Bias in Attitudes Toward Corruption. *Comparative Political Studies*, 46 (12), 1664-1692. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0010414013489081>
- Arechar, A. A., Allen, J., Berinsky, A. J., Cole, R., Epstein, Z., Garimella, K., Gully, A., Lu, J. G., Ross, R. M., Stagnaro, M. N., Zhang, Y., Pennycook, G., & Rand, D. G. (2023). Understanding and combatting misinformation across 16 countries on six continents. *Nature Human Behaviour*, 1-12. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-023-01641-6>
- Bachmann, I., & Valenzuela, S. (2023). Studying the Downstream Effects of Fact-Checking on Social Media: Experiments on Correction Formats, Belief Accuracy, and Media Trust. *Social Media + Society*, 9 (2). <https://doi.org/10.1177/20563051231179694>
- Bachmann, I., Valenzuela, S., Mujica, C., Labarca, C., Grassau, D., & Halpern, D. (2024). A Credibility Divide? Discerning Truth From Misinformation in Chile. *International Journal of Public Opinion Research*, 36 (3). <https://doi.org/10.1093/ijpor/edae017>
- Badrinathan, S. (2021). Educative Interventions to Combat Misinformation: Evidence from a Field Experiment in India. *American Political Science Review*, 115 (4), 1325-1341.
<https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055421000459>
- Barifouse, R., Mori, L., & Allen, A. (2022). Eleições 2022: Quais são as propostas de Lula e Bolsonaro? *BBC News Brasil*. <https://www.bbc.com/portuguese/brasil-63117592>

- Baron, J. (2019). Actively open-minded thinking in politics. *Cognition*, 188, 8-18.
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2018.10.004>
- Batista Pereira, F., Bueno, N., Nunes, F., & Pavão, N. (2022, August). Inoculation Reduces Misinformation: Experimental Evidence from a Multidimensional Intervention in Brazil. <https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.4185949>
- Batista Pereira, F., Bueno, N. S., Nunes, F., & Pavão, N. (2022). Fake News, Fact Checking, and Partisanship: The Resilience of Rumors in the 2018 Brazilian Elections. *The Journal of Politics*, 84 (4), 2188-2201. <https://doi.org/10.1086/719419>
- Blair, R. A., Gottlieb, J., Nyhan, B., Paler, L., Argote, P., & Stainfield, C. J. (2023). Interventions to counter misinformation: Lessons from the Global North and applications to the Global South. *USAID*, 55, 101732. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.copsyc.2023.101732>
- Blais, A., & Gélinau, F. (2007). Winning, Losing and Satisfaction with Democracy. *Political Studies*, 55 (2), 425-441. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9248.2007.00659.x>
- Born, K. (2017, June). The future of truth: Can philanthropy help mitigate misinformation? <https://hewlett.org/future-truth-can-philanthropy-help-mitigate-misinformation/>
- Carreras, M., & İrepoğlu, Y. (2013). Trust in elections, vote buying, and turnout in Latin America. *Electoral Studies*, 32 (4), 609–619.
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.electstud.2013.07.012>
- Carro, R. (2023). Brazil — Reuters Institute for the Study of Journalism.
<https://reutersinstitute.politics.ox.ac.uk/digital-news-report/2023/brazil>
- Coppock, A. (2022). *Persuasion in Parallel: How Information Changes Minds about Politics*. University of Chicago Press.
<https://press.uchicago.edu/ucp/books/book/chicago/P/bo181475008.html>

- Dahlberg, S., & Linde, J. (2018). Socialization or Experience? Institutional Trust and Satisfaction with Democracy among Emigrants in Different Institutional Settings. *The Journal of Politics*, 80 (4), 1389-1393. <https://doi.org/10.1086/698661>
- Datafolha. (2022, August). Cresce confiança nas urnas eletrônicas [Section: Eleições]. <https://datafolha.folha.uol.com.br/eleicoes/2022/08/cresce-confianca-nas-urnas-eletronicas.shtml>
- Druckman, J. N., Peterson, E., & Slothuus, R. (2013). How Elite Partisan Polarization Affects Public Opinion Formation. *American Political Science Review*, 107 (1), 57-79. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055412000500>
- Dumitru, E.-A., Ivan, L., & Loos, E. (2022). A Generational Approach to Fight Fake News: In Search of Effective Media Literacy Training and Interventions. In Q. Gao & J. Zhou (Eds.), *Human Aspects of IT for the Aged Population. Design, Interaction and Technology Acceptance* (pp. 291-310). Springer International Publishing. <https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-05581-222>
- Ebeling, R., Saenz, C. A. C., Nobre, J. C., & Becker, K. (2022). Analysis of the Influence of Political Polarization in the Vaccination Stance: The Brazilian COVID-19 Scenario. *Proceedings of the International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media*, 16, 159-170. <https://doi.org/10.1609/icwsm.v16i1.19281>
- Edwards, L., Stoilova, M., Anstead, N., Fry, A., El-Halaby, G., & Smith, M. (2021, June). Rapid evidence assessment on online misinformation and media literacy: Final report for Ofcom. <https://www.ofcom.org.uk/research-and-data/internet-and-on-demand-research/online-nation>

Faiola, A. (2022). Bolsonaro vs. Lula: A referendum on Brazil's young democracy. *Washington Post*.

<https://www.washingtonpost.com/world/2022/09/28/brazil-election-bolsonaro-lula-democracy-authoritarianism/>

Foster, J. L., Huthwaite, T., Yesberg, J. A., Garry, M., & Loftus, E. F. (2012). Repetition, not number of sources, increases both susceptibility to misinformation and confidence in the accuracy of eyewitnesses. *Acta Psychologica*, 139 (2), 320-326.

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.actpsy.2011.12.004>

Freeman, D., Waite, F., Rosebrock, L., Petit, A., Causier, C., East, A., Jenner, L., Teale, A.-L., Carr, L., Mulhall, S., Bold, E., & Lambe, S. (2022). Coronavirus conspiracy beliefs, mistrust, and compliance with government guidelines in England. *Psychological Medicine*, 52 (2), 251-263. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0033291720001890>

Frenda, S. J., Nichols, R. M., & Loftus, E. F. (2011). Current Issues and Advances in Misinformation Research [Publisher: SAGE Publications Inc]. *Current Directions in Psychological Science*, 20 (1), 20–23. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0963721410396620>

Funk, C., Hefferon, M., Kennedy, B., & Johnson, C. (2019). Trust and Mistrust in Americans' Views of Scientific Experts.

Furtado, A. L. F. (2019). 'Presidente livre e independente': A construção de Jair Bolsonaro como político outsider no horário eleitoral (2018) [Accepted: 2021-01-13T16:14:19Z].

Retrieved December 11, 2023, from <http://repositorio.ufc.br/handle/riufc/56016>

Galhardi, C. P., Freire, N. P., Fagundes, M. C. M., Minayo, M. C. d. S., & Cunha, I. C. K. O. (2022). Fake News and vaccine hesitancy in the COVID-19 pandemic in Brazil. *Ciência & Saúde Coletiva*, 27, 1849-1858.

<https://doi.org/10.1590/1413-81232022275.24092021EN>

- Gehle, L., Hameleers, M., Tulin, M., de Vreese, C., Aalberg, T., Van Aelst, P., S. Cardenal, A., Corbu, N., van Erkel, P., Esser, F., Halagiera, D., Hopmann, D., Koç-Michalska, K., Matthes, J., Meltzer, C., Splendore, S., Stanyer, J., Stępińska, A., Štětka, V.,... Zoizner, A. (2024). Misinformation Detection in the Context of the Russian Invasion of Ukraine: Evidence From Original Survey Data Collected in 19 Democracies. *International Journal of Public Opinion Research*, 36 (3). <https://doi.org/10.1093/ijpor/edad040>
- Gottlieb, J., Adida, C. L., & Moussa, R. (2022). Reducing Misinformation in a Polarized Context: Experimental Evidence from Côte d'Ivoire. <https://doi.org/10.26085/C3Q30T>
- Gramacho, W., Turgeon, M., Kennedy, J., Stabile, M., & Mundim, P. S. (2021). Political Preferences, Knowledge, and Misinformation About COVID-19: The Case of Brazil. *Frontiers in Political Science*, 3. <https://www.frontiersin.org/articles/10.3389/fpos.2021.646430>
- Hale, S. A., Belisario, A., Mostafa, A. N., & Camargo, C. (2024). Analyzing Misinformation Claims During the 2022 Brazilian General Election on WhatsApp, Twitter, and Kwai. *International Journal of Public Opinion Research*, 36 (3). <https://doi.org/10.1093/ijpor/edae032>
- Hernández, E., Anduiza, E., & Rico, G. (2021). Affective polarization and the salience of elections. *Electoral Studies*, 69. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.electstud.2020.102203>
- Hooghe, M., & Oser, J. (2017). Partisan strength, political trust and generalized trust in the United States: An analysis of the General Social Survey, 1972-2014. *Social Science Research*, 68, 132-146. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ssresearch.2017.08.005>
- Horton, J., & Gragnani, J. (2022). Brazil election: Accusations and misinformation on the

- campaign trail. *BBC News*. <https://www.bbc.com/news/63374100>
- Huntington, S. P. (1991). Democracy's Third Wave. *Journal of Democracy*, 2 (2), 12-34.
<https://doi.org/10.1353/jod.1991.0016>
- JB, P. (2022, August). Mais de 156,45 milhões de pessoas estão aptas a votar em outubro.
<https://www.jb.com.br/pais/politica/2022/08/1038988-mais-de-15645-milhoes-de-pessoas-estao-aptas-a-votar-em-outubro.html>
- Kahan, D. M. (2012, November). Ideology, Motivated Reasoning, and Cognitive Reflection: An Experimental Study. <https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.2182588>
- Kahan, D. M., Peters, E., Dawson, E. C., & Slovic, P. (2017). Motivated numeracy and enlightened self-government. *Behavioural Public Policy*, 1 (1), 54-86.
<https://doi.org/10.1017/bpp.2016.2>
- Keefer, P., & Scartascini, C. (2022, January). *Trust: The key to social cohesion and growth in Latin America and the Caribbean*. Inter-American Development Bank.
<https://doi.org/10.18235/0003792>
- Klein, E., & Robison, J. (2020). Like, Post, and Distrust? How Social Media Use Affects Trust in Government. *Political Communication*, 37(1), 46–64.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/10584609.2019.1661891>
- Kreiss, D. (2019). The Fragmenting of the Civil Sphere: How Partisan Identity Shapes the Moral Evaluation of Candidates and Epistemology. In J. L. Mast & J. C. Alexander (Eds.), *Politics of Meaning/Meaning of Politics: Cultural Sociology of the 2016 U.S. Presidential Election* (pp. 223-241). Springer International Publishing.
<https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-95945-013>
- Levendusky, M. S. (2013). Why Do Partisan Media Polarize Viewers? *American Journal*

- of Political Science*, 57 (3), 611-623. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12008>
- Levitsky, S., & Ziblatt, D. (2018). *How Democracies Die* (First edition.). Crown. Lewandowsky, S., Ecker, U. K. H., Seifert, C. M., Schwarz, N., & Cook, J. (2012). Misinformation and Its Correction: Continued Influence and Successful Debiasing. *Psychological Science in the Public Interest*, 13 (3), 106-131. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/23484653>
- Lim, G., & Donovan, J. (2020, October). Detect, Document, and Debunk. <https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780197510636.013.44>
- Little, A. T. (2019). The Distortion of Related Beliefs. *American Journal of Political Science*, 63(3), 675–689. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12435>
- Lodge, M., & Taber, C. S. (2013, April). *The Rationalizing Voter*. Cambridge University Press.
- Lourenço, M. (2022, May). Saiba por que o voto eletrônico é seguro em nova série de vídeos sobre eleições 2022 [Section: Tv Folha]. <https://www1.folha.uol.com.br/tv/2022/05/saiba-por-que-o-voto-eletronico-e-seguro-em-nova-serie-de-videos-sobre-eleicoes-de-2022.shtml>
- Lupu, N., Bustamante, M. V. R., & Zechmeister, E. J. (2020). Social Media Disruption: Messaging Mistrust in Latin America. *Journal of Democracy*, 31(3), 160–171.
- Majerczak, P., & Strzelecki, A. (2022). Trust, Media Credibility, Social Ties, and the Intention to Share towards Information Verification in an Age of Fake News. *Behavioral Sciences*, 12 (2), 51. <https://doi.org/10.3390/bs12020051>
- Marra, R. (2022, August). Eleições 2022: Conheça o plano de governo de Luiz In´acio Lula da Silva [Section: Poder]. <https://www1.folha.uol.com.br/poder/2022/08/eleicoes-2022-conheca-o-plano-de-gover>

no-de-luiz-inacio-lula-da-silva.shtml

- Masala, A. (2020). Populism as the Crisis of Political Trust. In A. Fabris (Ed.), *Trust* (pp. 187-197). Springer International Publishing. <https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-3044018-313>
- Mauk, M., & Grömping, M. (2023). Online Disinformation Predicts Inaccurate Beliefs About Election Fairness Among Both Winners and Losers. *Comparative Political Studies*, 00104140231193008. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00104140231193008>
- Mello, F., & Jurado, I. (2026). Following the Leader Against Democracy? Evidence From the 2022 Brazilian Presidential Election. *Politics and Governance*, 14(0). <https://doi.org/10.17645/pag.11547>
- Miller, J. M., Saunders, K. L., & Farhart, C. E. (2016). Conspiracy Endorsement as Motivated Reasoning: The Moderating Roles of Political Knowledge and Trust. *American Journal of Political Science*, 60 (4), 824–844. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12234>
- Modgil, S., Singh, R. K., Gupta, S., & Dennehy, D. (2021). A Confirmation Bias View on Social Media Induced Polarisation During Covid-19. *Information Systems Frontiers*. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10796-021-10222-9>
- Moy, P., Pfau, M., & Kahlor, L. (1999). Media use and public confidence in democratic institutions. *Journal of Broadcasting & Electronic Media*, 43(2), 137–158. <https://doi.org/10.1080/08838159909364481>
- Nadeau, R., Daoust, J.-F., & Dassonneville, R. (2023). Winning, Losing, and the Quality of Democracy. *Political Studies*, 71 (2), 483-500. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00323217211026189>
- Nan, X., Wang, Y., & Thier, K. (2022). Why do people believe health misinformation and who is at risk? A systematic review of individual differences in susceptibility to health

misinformation. *Social Science & Medicine*, 314.

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.socscimed.2022.115398>

Nicas, J., & Spigariol, A. (2022). On Eve of Election, Bolsonaro's Party Attacks Brazil's Voting Systems. *The New York Times*.

<https://www.nytimes.com/2022/09/29/world/americas/election-bolsonaro-brazil-fraud.html>

Noh, S., & Soroka, S. (2025). Negativity Biases Online. *Journal of Media Psychology*, 37(5), 296–306. <https://doi.org/10.1027/1864-1105/a000479>

Pennycook, G., & Rand, D. G. (2019). Lazy, not biased: Susceptibility to partisan fake news is better explained by lack of reasoning than by motivated reasoning. *Cognition*, 188, 39–50. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2018.06.011>

Pennycook, G., & Rand, D. G. (2021a). The Psychology of Fake News. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences*, 25 (5), 388-402. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tics.2021.02.007>

Pennycook, G., & Rand, D. G. (2021b). *Examining false beliefs about voter fraud in the wake of the 2020 Presidential Election* (preprint). <https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/szdgb>

Peterson, E., & Iyengar, S. (2021). Partisan Gaps in Political Information and Information-Seeking Behavior: Motivated Reasoning or Cheerleading? *American Journal of Political Science*, 65 (1), 133-147. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12535>

Reeves, P. (2018). Dictatorship Was A 'Very Good' Period, Says Brazil's Aspiring President. NPR. Retrieved December 11, 2023, from <https://www.npr.org/2018/07/30/631952886/dictatorship-was-a-very-good-period-says-brazil-s-aspiring-president>

Ribbeiro, L. (2026, January 13). Eleições 2026: Uso das urnas eletrônicas no Brasil completa 30

anos. *CNN Brasil*.

<https://www.cnnbrasil.com.br/eleicoes/eleicoes-2026-uso-das-urnas-eletronicas-no-brasil-completa-30-anos/>

Rodríguez, M., & Zechmeister, E. J. (2018). Media Pluralism, Public Trust, and Democracy: New Evidence from Latin America and the Caribbean. *mediadev*.

Roozenbeek, J., Maertens, R., Herzog, S. M., Geers, M., Kurvers, R., Sultan, M., & Linden, S. v. d. (2022). Susceptibility to misinformation is consistent across question framings and response modes and better explained by myside bias and partisanship than analytical thinking. *Judgment and Decision Making*, 17 (3), 547-573.

<https://doi.org/10.1017/S1930297500003570>

Roozenbeek, J., Schneider, C. R., Dryhurst, S., Kerr, J., Freeman, A. L. J., Recchia, G., van der Bles, A. M., & van der Linden, S. (2020). Susceptibility to misinformation about COVID-19 around the world. *Royal Society Open Science*, 7 (10).

<https://doi.org/10.1098/rsos.201199>

Rossini, P., & Kalogeropoulos, A. (2021). Informação e Desinformação sobre a Covid-19 no Brasil. *Communication and Media*.

Rossini, P., Mont'Alverne, C., & Kalogeropoulos, A. (2023). Explaining beliefs in electoral misinformation in the 2022 Brazilian election: The role of ideology, political trust, social media, and messaging apps. *Harvard Kennedy School Misinformation Review*.

<https://doi.org/10.37016/mr-2020-115>

Rubenson, D. (2021). Tie my hands loosely: Pre-analysis plans in political science. *Politics and the Life Sciences*, 40 (2), 142-151. <https://doi.org/10.1017/pls.2021.23>

Scherer, L. D., & Pennycook, G. (2020). Who Is Susceptible to Online Health Misinformation?

American Journal of Public Health, 110 (S3), S276-S277.

<https://doi.org/10.2105/AJPH.2020.305908>

Silva, V. H. (2022, June). 81% da população brasileira acessou a internet em 2021, diz pesquisa; TV supera computador como meio.

<https://g1.globo.com/tecnologia/noticia/2022/06/21/81percent-da-populacao-brasileira-acessou-a-internet-em-2021-diz-pesquisa.ghtml>

Singh, S. P. (2014). Not all election winners are equal: Satisfaction with democracy and the nature of the vote. *European Journal of Political Research*, 53 (2), 308-327.

<https://doi.org/10.1111/1475-6765.12028>

Treen, K. M. d., Williams, H. T. P., & O'Neill, S. J. (2020). Online misinformation about climate change. *WIREs Climate Change*, 11 (5). <https://doi.org/10.1002/wcc.665>

Uslaner, E. M. (2002, September). *The Moral Foundations of Trust*. Social Science Research Network. Rochester, NY. <https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.824504>

Valenzuela, S., Halpern, D., & Araneda, F. (2022). A Downward Spiral? A Panel Study of Misinformation and Media Trust in Chile. *The International Journal of Press/Politics*, 27 (2), 353-373. <https://doi.org/10.1177/19401612211025238>

Van der Meer, T. G. L. A., Hameleers, M., & Kroon, A. C. (2020). Crafting Our Own Biased Media Diets: The Effects of Confirmation, Source, and Negativity Bias on Selective Attendance to Online News. *Mass Communication and Society*, 23 (6), 937-967. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15205436.2020.1782432>

Vedejová, D., & Čavojová V. (2022). Confirmation bias in information search, interpretation, and memory recall: Evidence from reasoning about four controversial topics. *Thinking & Reasoning*, 28 (1), 1-28. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13546783.2021.1891967>

- Weeks, B. E. (2015). Emotions, Partisanship, and Misperceptions: How Anger and Anxiety Moderate the Effect of Partisan Bias on Susceptibility to Political Misinformation. *Journal of Communication*, 65 (4), 699-719. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jcom.12164>
- West, D. M. (2017, December). How to combat fake news and disinformation. Retrieved May 23, 2022, from <https://www.brookings.edu/research/how-to-combat-fake-news-and-disinformation/>
- Yamaguti, B. (2023, June). Manifestações de junho de 2013: Passada uma década, pessoas que participaram dos atos relembram os protestos. Retrieved July 17, 2023, from <https://g1.globo.com/df/distrito-federal/noticia/2023/06/04/manifestacoes-de-junho-de-2013-passada-uma-decada-pessoas-que-participaram-dos-atos-relembra-os-protestos.ghtml>
- Zhu, B., Chen, C., Loftus, E. F., Lin, C., He, Q., Chen, C., Li, H., Xue, G., Lu, Z., & Dong, Q. (2010). Individual differences in false memory from misinformation: Cognitive factors. *Memory*, 18 (5), 543–555. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09658211.2010.487051>